We Interrupt This Transition

WE INTERRUPT THIS TRANSITION

The Throwaway Pitch

Pilot

Written by

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COLD OPEN

EXT. CANADIAN WILDERNESS - DAY

EXTREME CLOSE UP: A moose, DOUG, in full gallop. Nostrils flaring.

A man SCREAMS.

WIDER: A Jack Black-type MOUNTIE is riding the moose *backwards*, while the moose is running.

MOUNTIE
Faster, Doug! We've gotta save the molasses factory!

Doug lets out a deep, throaty MOOOAAARRR.

The molasses factory EXPLODES.

DOUG
(Canadianly)
Sorry!

MOUNTIE
Oh, that's your answer for everything, Doug!

Freeze frame.

VOICEOVER (V.O.)
Jack Buckley is Constable Rick Justice. With Doug the Moose, as himself. *American Mountie*. Season 7 Premieres Thursday. Exclusively on Garden Alpha.

ONSCREEN: "AMERICAN MOUNTIE: SEASON 7 PREMIERS [sic] THURSDAY."

EXT. GARDEN ALPHA OFFICES - DAY

We pull back and see that we've been looking at an outdoor display on a building exterior. The Garden Alpha logo is on the side of the building.

Walking past it, SAM CULVER (35, female, formal blazer, pencil skirt, British) and JIMMY HOWARD (45, Botany 500-inspired suit, American, game show host energy.) They walk-and-talk as they approach the medium-sized corporate building.

SAM
I can't *believe* American Mountie got a *seventh* season.

JIMMY
You're telling me. And I heard they film that here, in L.A. Using Hollywood to fake Vancouver. That's more ass-backwards than the moose.

SUPER: "FEBRUARY 2024 -- EIGHT MONTHS TO ELECTION DAY"

SAM
Why?

JIMMY
Maybe the moose is in SAG? You know. A union thing?

SAM
No, I mean *why* do some shows never get any traction -- no matter how brilliant, and the *stupidest* ideas get seven bloody seasons?

JIMMY
It all comes down to the pitch.

Jimmy grins. He's been waiting all morning to say this.

JIMMY (cont'd)
God, I love pitch days. Isn't this great, Sam?

SAM
(sarcastic)
It's wonderful, Jimmy. Especially for those of us who haven't made our careers yet.

JIMMY
Hey, hey, that's why we're here. We're going to get Garden Alpha to greenlight *Sabotage*, and then you, Sam, you're going to run your *own show*.

They arrive at the glass doors but don't go in yet.

Jimmy puts up a hand for a high five. Sam, frowns, worried, leaving Jimmy hanging.

Jimmy frowns, giving Sam his full attention.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Nervous?

SAM
If they say no, Jimmy, this is the last meeting we have.
(MORE)

SAM (cont'd)
Sabotage is a great format, but it might not be what the market wants right now.

JIMMY
Bah, forget market. The format's great, but the real value is *you*. *T*elevision needs creators like you.

SAM
I'm not a creator yet.

Jimmy looks in the glass door, then heads to the side, waving for Sam to join him. They continue the conversation next to a poster for "How It's Made: Legislation Edition" with a picture of sausage with American flags on it.

JIMMY
You absolutely are. You have an *instinct* for it. You just need someone to buy your show.

SAM
Jimmy, my instincts don't matter. The people with the checkbooks decide what's television.

JIMMY
The good news is that the people with the checkbooks can be convinced by a good pitch. Want to run over the plan one more time?

SAM
Please.

JIMMY
After the initial schmooze, we start with our throwaway pitch.

SAM
I still don't understand why.

JIMMY
Sam, it helps to think of execs as baby goldfish.

Sam looks at him incredulously.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Television has been ruining people's attention spans since Uncle Milty. And execs watch a lot of TV.

SAM
Occupational hazard, I guess.

JIMMY
So, execs *forget* the ideas they've passed on, and *remember* the ones they've greenlit. Any good, but untested idea, looks bad in comparison to a show in production... so...

SAM
So we give them a bad idea... fresh in their minds, to compare the good idea to.

JIMMY
Ah, but there's *psychology* at play. And a strategy that requires as much deft finesse as being in second place going into Final Jeopardy and figuring out how much to bet.

SAM
How much you need to tie plus a dollar, right?

Jimmy's eyes go wide.

JIMMY
Okay, yes. You're right. That's a bad example.
(pause)
Next time Ken Jennings visits the house, not a word.

SAM
Oh, I am *absolutely* telling Ken. So, go on.

JIMMY
Right. Give them a bad idea as bait. Let them think they're exercising power over you by passing on the bad pitch.
(beat)
Psychologically, that's when they're at their weakest... when they think they've got you where they want you. All figured out.
(a pause)
To quote Sun Tzu:
(steeples fingers)
"Mua ha ha. Mine is an evil laugh."

Sam frowns.

SAM
I talked to Daria Bryant on the phone. She's smart. She'll never fall for that.

JIMMY
They *always* fall for it. Every time.

SAM
Do you think we should have come up with a better bad idea?

JIMMY
We couldn't have possibly come up with a worse one.

Sam looks at Jimmy... letting herself be nervous. Then she shakes herself out. Puts on her game face.

SAM
Right. Let's do this.

Jimmy re-offers the high-five. Sam high-fives back.

They head in.

CUT TO TITLES:

ACT I

INT. GARDEN ALPHA LOBBY - DAY

Small, but plush, and absolutely that dot-com decor. Like a rumpus room and a cubicle farm had a baby.

A tall, broad shouldered woman, DARIA (early 30s, trans, though Sam and Jimmy don't clock it), in blue-jeans and a t-shirt with layered button-up tunic, and flat sandals that show off rainbow-painted toenails, greets Sam and Jimmy.

She practically beams seeing Jimmy.

DARIA
Oh my god! Jimmy Howard! I'm such a huge fan!

Jimmy smiles, points with finger guns. They shake hands.

DARIA (cont'd)
And you must be Sam Culver? Nice to finally meet you face to face.

Daria offers a handshake. Sam takes it.

SAM
Likewise. So do I call you Ms. Bryant, or Daria?

DARIA
Just call me Daria. The corporate culture here at Garden is very informal. C'mon in. Really looking forward to the ideas you have to pitch. Loved your work on 'The Martinet'. That show is *amazing*.

SAM
Thanks, but I can't take the credit. It was really Allen Brass's idea. I just... tee-vee-ified it.

DARIA
You *are* British. A Californian showrunner would *absolutely* take the credit and run with it.

Jimmy points to between himself and Sam.

JIMMY
Don't worry. We'll get her assimilated before too long. When she drove us here, she only veered onto the left side of the road twice. Progress.

Sam glares at Jimmy. Jimmy awkwardly clears his throat.

SAM
Martinet was how we met actually. Network brought me over from the UK to do the American adaptation and recruited Jimmy as host.

DARIA
How did that go?

JIMMY
(smiling)
Terrible!

SAM
He's too nice to host that show.

JIMMY
I have my moments. But she recognized it, fought the
(MORE)

JIMMY (cont'd)
network on it. The network overruled her. She was right.

DARIA
So that disaster's what pushed you two into business together?

JIMMY
I know genius and talent when I see it.

SAM
And I... know Jimmy.

Daria snickers.

DARIA
Well, then. Let's see what you've got.

INT. DARIA'S OFFICE - DAY

Not a typical exec office. Daria's desk faces the wall. Multiple monitors. Foliage. Natural light. She has a *trans pride flag* prominently on her desk. Daria sits in a swivel office chair with a large cup of coffee. Sam takes a seat on an adjacent couch with a cup of tea.

Sam and Jimmy spot the trans flag but don't think anything of it.

DARIA
So. Let's start. What's your first pitch?

SAM
Yep. Here goes.
(deep breath)
The first one is a reality show called "*Gender Island*."

Sam hands over a one-page pitch document from a portfolio.

Daria blinks.

DARIA
"*Gender Island*."

JIMMY
Working title.

SAM
We take eight or so men, real manly men, you know?

JIMMY
The kind of men you'd like to see taken down a peg.

Daria stares. Blankly. Sam continues anyway, though she seems more nervous than she should be. Jimmy is calm and comfortable, crossing his legs, leaning back.

SAM
We set them up in an isolation area -- an island or a Big Brother type house. Then we tell them that they can quit any time, but that everyone who makes it all the way through gender transitioning gets an equal share of a million dollars.

Daria's eyes are wide.

DARIA
Gender transitioning?

Sam nods. Pauses a little too long.

SAM
Yes. Into women.

Daria's surprised, shocked. But morbidly curious. She tilts her head, confused.

JIMMY
(grinning)
I know, right?

DARIA
And these contestants -- they'd be trans women?

SAM
No... just... uh men, normal-- I mean... cisgender men.

Daria's brow furrows. She sips some coffee. She stares at the one-pager, wide-eyed.

DARIA
Oh. That seems... wow. Uh. Wow. that's... *a take*.
(beat)
A very... *bold*. Very... *creative* take.
(beat)
Are we talking... elimination format?

JIMMY
More of a hands-on-a-pickup truck sort of thing. They can drop out any time, take the money they've won.

SAM
Tension. Suspense. Anyone could drop at any moment.

JIMMY
(grinning)
And when they do, they have to look at the camera and say--

Jimmy holds his hands out like he's framing himself in a TV screen.

JIMMY (cont'd)
"I'm just not man enough to be a woman."

Sam tries to hold the poker face, but there's a bit of cringe sneaking in. Jimmy's poker face is impeccable.

Daria blinks, deeply thinking about this. She's sipping coffee. Eyebrows are raised.

DARIA
Let's... put that on the back-burner for now. What's the other idea?

Sam smiles, relieved.

SAM
It's called *Sabotage*. Trivia-based traditional game show with a social deduction element. *Traitors* meets *Weakest Link*.

JIMMY
Tell her the best part, Sam.

SAM
The rounds are only six minutes long. Perfect for first run, but also great for GardenTube as a short-form second-run.

Daria smiles. Nods.

DARIA
And you managed to hook *Jimmy Howard* as host?

JIMMY
She persuaded me to come out of semi-retirement. Always said I would. For the right project.

DARIA
I mean... your name goes a long way. This'd be your first hosting gig since...

JIMMY
Shark Attack.

Daria nods.

DARIA
That show made a lot of people a lot of money...

JIMMY
And we're not talking about the *contestants*.

SAM
We discussed this in detail.

JIMMY
I'm happy producing, but I'd be willing to get back in front of the camera. For the right project.

DARIA
That *would* be kind of a coup.
(beat, smirks)
God, Sam, I'd love to know what it's like to work with him.

SAM
(soft shrug)
He's a character...

Sam sips her tea. Daria’s got a furrowed brow -- already thinking logistics.

EXT. JIMMY'S BACKYARD - DAY

It is a sunny day in Santa Monica. Golden hour. We're in the backyard of a small but *expensive* house. It has its own guest house.

There we see Sam pacing back and forth in casual clothes, while Jimmy, is changed out of his suit into a Hawaiian shirt and khakis, sitting in the shade on reclined patio furniture, sipping from a water bottle. There's a bucket full of them, with some ice.

In contrast to the nervous Sam, Jimmy is completely relaxed.

JIMMY
Sam. *Sam*.

Sam stops pacing.

JIMMY (cont'd)
You're worried over nothing. You did great.

SAM
You think so?

JIMMY
I do, Sam. And you know I don't blow smoke up the asses of my friends. I keep my smoke blowing strictly professional.

Jimmy takes a swig.

JIMMY (cont'd)
First thing I learned in my career-- get as much smoke into *asses* as possible.

SAM
What a pleasant image.

JIMMY
There's no shame in using a funnel and bellows, it's old fashioned, but effective, and the smoke has to get *way* up in there.

Sam finally sits down, but she doesn't relax.

SAM
I just hate the way that Los Angeles does business. Maybe I should go back to England, maybe?

JIMMY
You've *done* England. Short contracts, small budgets. Audience of dozens. *And* the weather sucks.

Sam finally grabs a water bottle.

SAM
The weather's not that bad. Better than here.

JIMMY
(beat)
I *cannot* believe you just said that.

SAM
It's true. The weather here is... too *saccharine*. Too mild. It's too pleasant. You ever meet someone who was just *too pleasant, all the time,* Jimmy?

JIMMY
Sam... I'm a *game show host*.

SAM
You know what I mean. Give me... give me weather with *character*.

JIMMY
Southern California's weather has character! What about the wildfires?

SAM
That, if anything, is *too much character*.
(beat)
I'm worried about the throwaway pitch. What if it was just... *too stupid?*

JIMMY
It's an *incredibly stupid industry*, Sam. I wouldn't be a success story if it wasn't. I mean *Shark Attack?* One of the best designed game shows ever, and no one was even considering it until I had the stupid idea to say: "Let's just put little cartoon sharks in it that eat the contestant's money!" Boom. Niche nerd trivia night to prime time success.

Sam scrunches her face, then changes the subject.

SAM
What was that flag on her desk?

JIMMY
What flag?

SAM
The one on Daria's desk. Blue, pink, white, pink, blue?
(MORE)

SAM (cont'd)
(beat)
Belize?

Jimmy scoffs.

JIMMY
No, Sam.
(beat, swig)
It's "Espirito Santo."

Sam turns to him.

SAM
What?

JIMMY
State flag of Espirito Santo.
One of the states of Brazil.
Blue. Pink. White.

SAM
You're filled with the oddest
information, Jimmy.

JIMMY
I read trivia questions from
blue index cards for a living.
Some of that stuff sticks.

Sam nods. Then laughs.

SAM
Oh, god, I just had a terrible
thought. What if they actually
liked our throwaway pitch?

JIMMY
No way. It would be in
incredibly bad taste. It's an
insult to decency, ethics, and
intelligence.

SAM
That's the problem. It's *perfect*
for television.

JIMMY
No.
(a pause)
Maybe Fox.

EXT. DARIA'S APARTMENT - EASTSIDE LOS ANGELES - DUSK

Establishing. Daria's car pulls into the parking bay.

INT. DARIA'S APARTMENT - EASTSIDE LOS ANGELES - DUSK

Daria unlocks the door to her apartment, phone tucked between shoulder and ear, mid-call with CHANDRA (30s, Black, sharp).

She drops her bag onto the couch and slumps down next to it.

DARIA
...yeah, it was the *weirdest* pitch. Gender transitioning. As a *reality show*.
(pause)
The *idea* sucked. Culver doesn't, though. She did her homework, came up with a format, knew our verticals and got *Jimmy freaking Howard* attached to the project.
(beat)
It's a shame it's just not what we're looking for.

She grabs the remote, turns on the TV. Volume low or off.

INSERT: SILENCE OF THE LAMBS — the infamous mirror scene.

DARIA (cont'd)
Still, I couldn't stop thinking about that stupid "Gender Island" show on the drive home. And... okay, yeah, it sounds crazy, but if the same woman who created that great game show pitch and the mind behind *Shark Attack* sees something in it... I mean... maybe they're seeing something I'm not?
(a pause)
Well, of *course* people would *watch it*, Chandra. If it was legal to televise snuff films people would *watch*.
(a pause)
Anyway, I'll see you tomorrow at work... I think I'm just going to chill tonight. See you.

She hangs up the phone and sees what's already on the TV.

She rolls her eyes, and changes the channel.

An advertisement for Garden Alpha. Clips of "American Mountie" and "Vampires & Lesbians"

TV COMMERCIAL
Sign up today for a 30 day free trial of Garden Alpha and get
(MORE)

TV COMMERCIAL (cont'd)
your favorite movies and TV shows along with all of our great original programming. Www-dot-garden-dot-alpha.

Back to the movie.

INSERT: ACE VENTURA — the “reveal” scene.

DARIA
(at the TV)
--for fuck's sake...

She changes the channel again.

INSERT: RNN (Respectable News Network).

The on-screen CHYRON: TRANSGENDER ATHLETES CONTROVERSY

Daria grunts, slumps deeper into the couch. Changes the channel again, like the TV is attacking her personally.

INSERT — TV SCREEN: Kids in robes. Flying brooms. A gaudy crest fills the frame. Latin motto: PECUNIA EX HOC LOCO ALIT TENEBRAS ET ODIUM <Money from this place feeds darkness and hate.>

Daria freezes. Stares at the screen. Her expression shifts--first disbelief, then rage.

She pauses the TV. Pulls out her phone. Dials back.

DARIA (cont'd)
(into phone)
Hey. So... just a thought experiment. Not committing to anything--yet.
(beat)
But what if we could do *Gender Island*--but actually *do it right?*
(beat)
Show what transitioning really looks like. Not trauma. Not punchline.

She stares at the TV. Tightens her jaw.

DARIA (cont'd)
I *am* serious.
(smirking)
And don’t call me Shirley.
(pause)
What changed my mind?

She stares long at the warlock children frozen mid-spell. The Latin crest blazing.

DARIA (cont'd)
Because someone *will* make something like this eventually.
(beat)
And as bad as it is...
(beat)
We're the *only shot* at doing it right.

ACT II-A

EXT. JIMMY'S BACKYARD - DAY

Semi-establishing. Sam is heading from the guest house over to Jimmy's back patio door (connected to the kitchen) with a spring in her step.

INT. JIMMY'S KITCHEN - DAY

JIMMY, grumpy-tired and in his bathrobe, brews coffee in a single-serving machine.

A KNOCK at the patio doors. It's SAM. She's beaming.

Jimmy, half-awake, sees her and smiles as he opens the door.

SAM
We got a callback, Jimmy!

JIMMY
That's great, Sam. But isn't it a bit early in the morning?

SAM
It's ten-thirty.

Jimmy checks the microwave clock. It blinks 12:00 like it's been doing that for months.

JIMMY
I'll take your word for it. C'mon in. Coffee?

She steps inside.

SAM
Sure. Garden Alpha. They want us to come in today--re-pitch to the decision makers.

This perks Jimmy up more than the coffee ever could.

JIMMY
Today? That's quick. What time?

SAM
Three. I'm just about to change into my good pantsuit. What are you going with?

JIMMY
Botany 500.

Jimmy drinks coffee. Sam glares.

SAM
Jimmy. They stopped making Botany 500 when you were a *kid*.

JIMMY
I have to get mine special made. Classics never go out of style.

SAM
Ha. No. Think Drew Carey, not Bob Barker.

JIMMY
You know, I heard he was buried in his? Got as close as he could to 100 without going over.

Jimmy gestures to the air with his mug.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Now *that's* dedication to craft!

SAM
Too soon.

JIMMY
God, I'm so excited for you, Sam! This is it! I can feel it!

SAM
Whoa, whoa, we haven't signed any paperwork yet. Don't jinx it.

JIMMY
(playful)
I will jinx as I damn well please in my own kitchen!

Then, a beat. He shifts, sincere.

JIMMY (cont'd)
But seriously, Sam. Garden Alpha’s the perfect fit for *Sabotage*. It’s a fait accompli.

He spreads his arms, triumphant.

JIMMY (cont'd)
What could go wrong?

INT. GARDEN ALPHA LOBBY — DAY

Sam and Jimmy return to the offices. Daria spots them and lights up.

SAM
Hello again, Daria!

DARIA
Sam! So good to see you two again.

JIMMY
Likewise.

DARIA
I shared everything.
(beat)
They were skeptical but I talked them around. Now they're almost as excited as I am.

Sam and Jimmy exchange a glance--hopeful, a little charged.

SAM
Wonderful!

INT. GARDEN ALPHA CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

DARYL (50s) in blue jeans, a bowling shirt, and a sport coat. CHANDRA (30s, sharply dressed, Black, professional,) sits beside him--impeccable.

Daria leads Sam and Jimmy into the room.

DARIA
Sam, Jimmy -- this is Chandra, VP of Marketing and Daryl, VP of programming. Daryl, Chandra -- Sam and Jimmy.

DARYL
Pleased to meet you both.

SAM
Likewise. Shall we jump right in?

They all nod. Jimmy takes a seat, along with the network execs. Sam connects her laptop to a screen -- already on slide three of a prepared pitch deck.

SAM (cont'd)
So, I'm proposing twenty episodes, filmed over four days, with a runtime of twenty-two minutes each.
(beat)
Budget -- excluding prizes and talent -- is estimated at one-seventy on the low end, with a two-hundred cap if we handle all production. We could probably get that down to one-thirty if you've got sunk costs we can use.

Chandra, Daryl, and Daria exchange puzzled glances

CHANDRA
I'm sorry--*Filmed over four days?*

Sam's caught off guard.

SAM
Uh--yes? With a fifth day for reshoots or technical issues. Pretty standard...?

Three confused executives stare back. That's never good. Sam glances to Jimmy for backup.

He shrugs, calm.

JIMMY
Yeah, that's pretty typical. Five a day, back to back. Most of the edit happens live in the control room.
(beat)
Long days, sure -- but back when I hosted *Shark Attack*, that was the norm.
(beat)
We only did three a day when I hosted *Rotten Eggs*, but that was a kids' show. Had to pad for juice boxes and meltdowns.
(beat)
And that was just the host.

Daryl double-checks something on his laptop, then looks up.

DARYL
Okay, I think there's been a mix-up.
(MORE)

DARYL (cont'd)
(beat)
Daria told me you had this wild *reality show* concept. *Gender Island?*

Sam's face drains of color. Daria flushes.

SAM
Ah.

Daria facepalms.

DARIA
I'm sorry. That's on me. I assumed you knew we were talking about *Gender Island*.
(beat)
Do you have a deck for that?

Sam does not. And it shows.

SAM
I... don't believe I have it with me.

CHANDRA
That's fine. NBD. Let's just shoot from the hip -- we'll get into projections later.
(beat)
Tell us more about the concept.

Sam blinks. The room awaits.

SAM
The concept. For *Gender Island*.

Silence.

SAM (cont'd)
The one where contestants are financially incentivized to medically transition despite not wanting to transition.
(beat)
That idea.

The gears are turning. Loudly. Sam is clearly stalling, trapped, scrambling for a brilliant pivot that doesn't exist.

SAM (cont'd)
I need to pee.

INT. GARDEN ALPHA LADIES BATHROOM - DAY

Smash to a sink with running water. Sam stares into the mirror, full meltdown mode.

SAM
What the hell? What the... bloody buggering hell? This has to be a prank. A hazing thing. Some kind of... cultural Americanism I have no context for.

Daria enters behind her, calm but watchful.

DARIA
Sam, is everything alright?

Sam glares.

DARIA (cont'd)
I'll take that as a no.

SAM
Daria. Be honest.
(takes a breath)
Is this a joke? A prank? I'm not on a hidden camera show, am I?
(beat, muttering)
Shit. A hidden camera show. Why didn't I think of that? That's way better.

DARIA
Already got two in development. No, Sam. What's going on?

SAM
You can't seriously be considering *Gender Island!?*

DARIA
Now *I'm* the one confused.

SAM
You were supposed to *hate* it. It was supposed to make *Sabotage* look good!

Daria's winces in realization, then leans on the sink herself.

DARIA
It was a throwaway pitch, wasn't it?

SAM
Yes!

They stand there for a moment. Daria frowns glumly, Sam frowns frustratedly. Finally.

DARIA
I really wanted this one.

Sam scoffs.

DARIA (cont'd)
In fact, it took me a while to realize it, but it's exactly the sort of pitch I've been hoping to hear since I started here.

Sam looks at Daria like she's crazy.

INT. GARDEN ALPHA CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Jimmy is holding court with Daryl and Chandra. He is in smoke-up-ass mode.

JIMMY
When Sam came up with the idea, I just started peppering her with questions: “What’s the prize structure?” “How far are we taking this?” “How many contestants?” Don’t get me wrong, I thought it was silly at first--But she talked me around. Fast. She's brilliant. But you know that.

He makes a show of relaxing in the chair.

DARYL
Same thing happened with Daria. We assumed it was some kind of joke. But she was fired up. Had a whole slate of ideas-- promotion, product placement, merch...

CHANDRA
It’s a watercooler show, right? Game shows are okay... no offense.

JIMMY
None taken.

CHANDRA
But we’re a streamer. What we need is a show that makes people say, “I gotta sign up for Garden Alpha to watch that.” That's why
(MORE)

CHANDRA (cont'd)
we're looking for exclusive, original content.

JIMMY
I'd say this is definitely original content.

He pauses in thought.

JIMMY (cont'd)
You're not worried about backlash from...

Chandra grins, leaning forward. She's *invested*.

CHANDRA
Backlash? Are you kidding? We *love* backlash.
(leans in)
Backlash means *buzz*. Buzz means *press*. Press means signups.

DARYL
It's basically a conversion funnel with picket signs. I mean, let's aim for a hit, but even a controversial flop will get people signing up for the free trial. From a business standpoint? It works if it's great, it works if it's awful. And this show's going to be one or the other.

Chandra grins.

CHANDRA
Or both!

Boom. It clicks into place for Jimmy. He gets it. He smiles like Bugs Bunny sweet-talking Elmer Fudd.

JIMMY
I've worked with a *lot* of people in this industry... And that's why I like working with the tech side. You folks? You've got *vision*.

CHANDRA
Vision--*and* venture capital.

INT. GARDEN ALPHA LADIES BATHROOM - DAY

SAM
So you're *trans?*

DARIA
Yes. You couldn't tell?

SAM
You look normal.

Daria looks disapprovingly at Sam.

SAM (cont'd)
Sorry. You just... I couldn't tell.

DARIA
I'm not exactly *stealth*. Didn't you see the flag on my desk?

SAM
Espirito Santo?

DARIA
What?!

SAM
Nevermind. But if you're trans, why would you even consider *Gender Island?*

Daria leans back up against the sinks, tilting her head, thinking.

DARIA
I want you to imagine a time when gay people *didn't really exist* on TV. Not as anything but a punchline. I mean, everyone knew Paul Lynde was gay. It was the world's worst-kept Secret Square.
(beat)
But if he actually came *out?* They'd have taken one of those Xs and *crucified* him on it.

Sam finally starts to relax, matching Daria's lean.

SAM
Ah. Like Larry Grayson.

DARIA
But then Ellen DeGeneres comes out, and continues to lead her sitcom. Then *Will & Grace*. Three-camera sitcom, network prime time. But the lead was *a non-campy gay man*. Not the comic relief. The *lead*. Top billing! Maybe it started as a gimmick,
(MORE)

DARIA (cont'd)
but eventually it was just... the new normal.

Sam nods, thinks for a moment.

SAM
Okay? What does that have to do with *Gender Island?*

DARIA
TV shapes culture. Culture shapes TV. You're talking about a show that shows people what it's *like* to *transition*.

Daria pauses. Looks to Sam to see if she gets it.

Sam looks clueless.

Daria leans against the sink. Choosing her words.

DARIA (cont'd)
The ignorance out there is *staggering*. Not just hatred-- though there's plenty of that. But plain old *not knowing*. People don't know what being trans *is*.
(beat)
I want to show them what transition really looks like. That being your gender is *innate*. Not a trend. Not a meme. Not a mind virus. If anything's been contagious, it's *transphobia*. And the media's been the disease vector.

She shakes her head, a wry smile.

DARIA (cont'd)
Giving cis men hormone therapy? *Inducing* dysphoria? It shows *why* cis people need to be cis. And, conversely, *why* trans people need to be trans.
(pause)
Or at least, I think that's what will happen.

Sam frowns.

SAM
That sounds horrifying.

DARIA
Dysphoria? It is. But it's the reality for trans people. And
(MORE)

DARIA (cont'd)
unlike the hypothetical contestants of your show, they can't just *walk away*.

Daria sighs deeply.

DARIA (cont'd)
I don't know. Maybe your show could engender some empathy.
(beat, smirks)
Pun *absolutely* intended.

SAM
Then... why not commission a sitcom with a trans lead? Like *Will & Grace*?

DARIA
Maybe someday. But we’re not *there* yet. But that's where you come in.

SAM
Me?

DARIA
Reality TV. It can prime the pump. Richard Hatch on Survivor. Will Wikle on Big Brother. People who'd never knowingly met an out gay person in their life suddenly had one in their living room every week. Did Team Guido solve homophobia? No. But it moved the needle.

Sam takes a moment, thinks, paces a bit. Then turns back to Daria.

SAM
Shouldn’t you hire a trans showrunner then? Someone who actually knows?

DARIA
Two reasons. First, the only trans showrunners I know are the Wachowskis. And I don't have *Matrix* money.
(pause)
And the second: It's *your* idea. Your creation.

Daria looks away, thinking.

DARIA (cont'd)
I know what it's like to have things taken away and changed without your input.

Sam frowns.

DARIA (cont'd)
Sam. I've seen your work. You're *good*. I want to hand you a budget and let you *run*.
(grinning)
And... aren't you even a little curious?

SAM
Curious about what?

DARIA
How it turns out. The *boys*. Will they stick it out for the money? Will they crack under pressure? Will they find themselves in a body that feels... wrong? Are any of them *eggs*?

SAM
Eggs?

DARIA
Eggs are trans women who don't know they're trans yet. Chicks who haven't come out of their shell.

SAM
That's a *thing*? I thought they all knew from childhood.

Daria gives her the most patient eye-roll in recorded human history.

DARIA
Sam.
(deep beat)
This is why we need your show.

SAM
I... Even if you... But it would never... And then there's the... I mean... I don't have a slide deck.

DARIA
Then make one. We'll say you're not feeling well--which, let's be honest, isn't a stretch-- and we'll reschedule.

SAM
You'd do that?

DARIA
Sam. We're women working in television. If we don't look out for each other... We get Rudins screaming at PAs. Whedons rewriting our trauma. We know how that story ends.

Sam gets a thousand yard stare.

DARIA (cont'd)
Sam.

SAM
Daria?

DARIA
If you want a picture of the future without women in television?
(beat)
It's James Corden.
(beat)
Hosting.
(beat)
On a human face.
(beat)
Forever.

INT. GARDEN ALPHA CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Jimmy is still answering questions, though Daryl is starting to look at his watch.

Jimmy also looks back to the door. His foot taps, nervously.

DARYL
Hmm. Sam and Daria have been in there a while. Hope everything's alright. But Jimmy -- maybe you could field a few questions?

Jimmy turns back to Daryl, foot tapping stops. Full confidence mode.

JIMMY
Sure, I'll give it a shot. Just remember, it's Sam's baby. I may get a few details wrong.

DARYL
How long do you figure for pre-production?

Jimmy thinks.

JIMMY
Ballpark? Three months. Maybe a little longer if casting gets tricky.

CHANDRA
Right. And one thing we've been thinking about -- Sam floated your name for host, but... I don't think the host should be a man.

DARYL
Honestly? Feels like the host should be a trans woman.

JIMMY
Makes sense.

CHANDRA
Like a *Laverne Cox* type. She'd never do it, of course, but... that's the vibe.

DARYL
But you're clearly passionate about this, and you've still got name recognition. How would you feel about coming on as co-producer? Maybe even... director?

Director? It's Christmas morning for Jimmy. He processes this for half a beat. Then lights up, smooth as butter.

JIMMY
Gee. I always *did* want to direct...

ACT II-B

EXT. LA HIGHWAY - DAY

Jimmy is driving an SUV, Sam is in the passenger seat.

SAM (PRE-LAP)
Oh, I am *right proper buggered,* Jimmy.

INT. JIMMY'S SUV - DAY

Inside the car, Sam is moments from a meltdown, Jimmy is smiling and optimistic about the whole thing.

SAM
This is it. This is how my career ends. I've *irrevocably bollocked* it. I've bollocked it so hard they're registering a minor earthquake in Surrey.

JIMMY
Sam, breathe. When you start to spiral, you get so British I need subtitles.

Sam glares at Jimmy.

JIMMY (cont'd)
So, Daria's going to reschedule. Plenty of time to pivot. Just prep a deck, show them our market research...

SAM
What market research? Jimmy, I created a show that was designed for the market to hate.

JIMMY
Daryl and Chandra seemed to like it.

SAM
Daryl and Chandra are *loonies*. They'd greenlight competitive waterboarding if you could convince them Dasani would want product placement.

Jimmy thinks for a second.

JIMMY
Do you think they might?

SAM
Jimmy! Jesus. I finally get my own shot at producing something of my own... and it's *Gender* bloody *Island*.

Sam slumps down in the seat.

SAM (cont'd)
I should have just told Daria no. Should have said: No thank you, good luck with it, but I have standards.

JIMMY
Why didn't you?

Sam grunts.

SAM
Because it's everything I ever wanted. Creator credit. My idea, from start to finish. And I don't dare put my name on it! I'll have to change my name to Alan Smithee and my pronouns to has slash been.

Jimmy steadies himself. Takes a breath.

JIMMY
Sam. It’s not that bad...

SAM
And *you*. You sat there in the room and... actually *sold* them on it *more*.

JIMMY
Well, it means a lot to you.

SAM
What did they do, offer to let you direct?

Silence.

SAM (cont'd)
(disgusted)
Oh, Jimmy...

JIMMY
Forget that. Look, maybe... maybe this idea isn't the best. But you're *in the room* now. Let them see you turn this pig's ear into a gold purse or whatever, and you'll never have to go begging for greenlights again.

SAM
(sotto)
Sow's ear to a silk purse.

Sam looks at him. Silent. Then, with dawning horror:

SAM (cont'd)
Oh god. I hate it... but you’re right.
(beat)
I got my wish granted. By a monkey's paw.

Sam's eyes blow wide. Complete mortification.

SAM (cont'd)
I'm going to produce televised forced feminization erotica.

JIMMY
Could be worse. Some of those stories are actually really good.

Sam turns. Slowly.

SAM
You read forced-fem smut?

Jimmy clears his throat.

JIMMY
I read all sorts of stuff. Market research. Trends in the erotica and pornography market are often ahead of cultural trends by a few months.

A beat. He flicks on the blinker, turns off the highway.

SAM
Jimmy... this isn't the way back to the house. Where are we headed?

JIMMY
Hamburger Mary's.

SAM
Hamburger Mary's? Isn't that a gay bar?

JIMMY
No--it's a drag bar.

SAM
What's the difference? And also, uh, congrats on coming out, I guess?

JIMMY
What? No. Sam, I'm not gay. I just figured the best way to pull you out of your *luvvy-jubbly British funk* is to start the research right away. I remember this place -- went on a bad date with a good woman there once.

SAM
You sure she was a woman, Jimmy?

Jimmy sighs.

JIMMY
She was a *hell* of a woman. Also, when we go in there, maybe... don't make jokes like that.

SAM
It's offensive?

JIMMY
It's *clichéd*. I mean, what do I know about what's offensive? I'm a straight white guy. But either way--jokes about what's in someone's pants? Not great.

SAM
It's *drag*, Jimmy. Ninety percent of it is going to be men dressed as women making jokes about their dick.

JIMMY
That's... ugh... It's different when--

SAM
Right. So why a drag bar?

JIMMY
Because I know jack-squat about trans people. You know jack-squat about trans people. And this?
(beat)
At least it's *trans-adjacent*.

INT. HAMBURGER MARY'S DRAG SHOW - DAY

Smash to an over-the-top drag queen, TRANSA JACENT (late 20s), is mid-scream, mid-glitter.

TRANSA
HEEEEEEEY! Gays, Theys, and Strays! I'm your host, Transa Jacent! Are we ready to PARTTAAAAAAAY?!

Sam, sitting next to Jimmy in the audience, shoots Jimmy the most *British* withering look possible.

JIMMY
(quietly)
...Oh, I get it.

Transa paces the stage.

TRANSA
Give it up for your bartenders, your baddies, and your backup dancers -- all underpaid, overworked, and tragically un-medicated!

The crowd whoops.

TRANSA (cont'd)
Now, some quick ground rules: If you're sitting there thinking, “Wait... am I allowed to laugh?” -- the answer is YES. If you're sitting there thinking, “Wait... am I allowed to BE HERE?” -- Honey... if you made it through the last five years without a single identity crisis? YOU'RE the weird one.

A beat, then Transa smiles warmly.

TRANSA (cont'd)
So loosen up, tip your queens, and remember: Gender is a construct -- But this *face* is under strict architectural regulation.

Music cue, crowd cheers.

Fade to later in the show. Sam’s actually enjoying herself. Jimmy looks *visibly annoyed*.

SAM
I can see why people like this. It's kind of like an adult version of Christmas panto.

She glances over. Jimmy's expression is pure discomfort. A raw, exposed nerve.

SAM (cont'd)
Jimmy, not having fun? This was your idea.

JIMMY
(annoyed beat)
Yes. Yes it was.

SAM
Not your thing?

JIMMY
I never got the appeal. I don’t know. Feels cheap. *Feels wrong*.

A pause.

JIMMY (cont'd)
I get the idea of gender-as-performance, but... Are we supposed to be impressed -- aroused -- disgusted? Is femininity being celebrated -- or mocked -- or both? How the hell do you even tell?

Another pause.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Despite what the host said, I'm not comfortable laughing until I know if I'm laughing with someone or at someone.

Sam's expression softens. She reaches out to him, awkwardly patting Jimmy on the back.

Jimmy gently waves her off.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Don't-- Don't mind me, Sam. It's good you're enjoying the show. Our work begins after the show when we try to make contact with someone and start asking questions.

Sam shakes her head.

SAM
No, I'm not letting you marinade in misery. Are these just bad memories? You said you went here before? With a date?

JIMMY
Yeah. Larissa. We were even getting kind of serious.

SAM
What happened?

JIMMY
I don't know. She was great. But I felt like I couldn't be the man she wanted me to be. Didn't know what to do.

SAM
You dumped her?

JIMMY
Maybe I was stupid. But she deserved someone that could make her happy... someone more complete. I think she's just 'the one that got away,' you know?

Transa is suddenly right next to Jimmy.

TRANSA
That is the *saddest* thing I've ever heard.

JIMMY
JESUS! How long have you been standing there?

TRANSA
Long enough that it was *funnier* when you finally noticed me.

Transa shakes her tip bucket.

Jimmy pulls out a $20 and drops it in. He straightens his collar. Instantly: the game show host mask. Like flipping a switch.

JIMMY
Actually, Sam and I were hoping to ask you a few questions after the show, if that’s alright?

Sam raises an eyebrow. She’s seen this version of him before -- the polished performer.

TRANSA
Thinking about-- Oh my god. You're Jimmy Howard!

Jimmy shrugs. Deadapan

JIMMY
I am?
(to the ceiling)
Al, this is the worst Quantum Leap yet!

Sam laughs.

JIMMY (cont'd)
We're working on a pitch. Reality show. We're here... doing field research.

TRANSA
You came to a drag show to work on a reality show pitch? Is
(MORE)

TRANSA (cont'd)
there room in the market for more?

JIMMY
That's one of the things we need to find out.

TRANSA
Then me and a couple of the girls'll find you after.

Transa shakes the tip bucket.

TRANSA (cont'd)
Gotta go. These things don't fill themselves. Nice to meet you, Jimmy. Nice to meet you Sam.

Jimmy nods. Transa moves on.

Jimmy's face resets -- back to annoyance and boredom. He lets out a long sigh.

Sam notices, and frowns.

INT. HAMBURGER MARY'S RESTAURANT BOOTH - DAY

Hamburger Mary's dining area looks like what a 1950's diner would look like if a 1950's diner could do drag. Deliberate retro tackiness.

Sam and Jimmy are sitting in one of the red-and-black circular booths.

A young man in a heavy metal band t-shirt and jeans slides into the booth next to Sam.

She stiffens.

This is JULIAN - mid-20s, tired, thoughtful. We know them better as TRANSA JACENT.

SAM
Excuse me!

JULIAN (TRANSA)
Oh, sorry. It's me. You wanted to talk? I figured it'd be easier if we joined you than if you joined us, considering you don't know what we look like out of--

Julian sees her confusion, backpedals hard.

JULIAN
I am *so sorry*. Didn't think. I'm Julian Richards. I'm just *exhausted* after a performance. As... Transa Jacent?

Realization.

SAM / JIMMY
Ohhhhh...

Jimmy smiles, genuinely. So does Sam.

They motion for him to take a seat, and two young gay men join him at the table, RHYS (20s) and LUKE (20s).

RHYS
Hey Julian. Are these the TV people you-- Oh! You're Jimmy Howard!

JIMMY
(wizened)
In *accordance with the prophecy*.

Sam groans, but laughs.

SAM
Jimmy, why are you like this?

JIMMY
I don't have to answer that. You're not my therapist.

RHYS
Well, I'm uh, I'm Rhys, this is my boyfriend, Luke.

LUKE
Hi! I used to watch you all the time when I was sick as a kid in elementary school and the Shark Attack reruns came on.

Luke does a shark impression.

LUKE (cont'd)
I'm-ma shark! Gonna eat your money! Om Nom Nom!

Jimmy's smile is now a little more forced.

RHYS
Julian, you didn't tell me you knew *Jimmy Howard!*

JULIAN
Just met. They had some questions about drag.

LUKE
Ask away.

JIMMY
Well, maybe I'll let Sam start. Go ahead -- tell them about your idea, Sam.

Sam kicks Jimmy under the table. *Hard*. Jimmy winces in pain.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Gah-haha! Or... I could explain. We were brainstorming some ideas with a streaming service, and we... had a... controversial idea. We wanted to... make sure we weren't about to do something stupid. Or worse-- exploitative. And-- we wanted to talk to some... trans women about it.

Julian, Rhys, and Luke all have confused looks on their faces.

JIMMY (cont'd)
And I thought... if we... I mean...

Luke laughs out loud.

LUKE
Oh my god! You mean you thought... *we* were trans women?

JULIAN
God, I don't think I know *any* trans women, now that I think about it. Not personally anyway.

SAM
You're kidding. Not one?

JULIAN
Mostly it's gay guys who do drag. I'm an exception -- my wife actually got me into it. I like to make people laugh, she likes to dress me in her clothes.

RHYS
That may be a part of it, you know. *Drag Race* mainstreamed a
(MORE)

RHYS (cont'd)
lot of drag culture, but... I don't actually know how trans people feel about it.

LUKE
I mean, if you really wanted to talk to trans people, why not check out the center?

JIMMY
The center?

LUKE
On Santa Monica Boulevard. The LGBT center. Five story building. Got a clinic, a pharmacy, educational support groups, all that stuff. It's literally down the street, just past Trader Joe's. I've sure I've seen posters for trans support groups and the like there.

SAM
(snarking britishly)
That seems like something we *should have done* in the *first place*, Jimmy.

JULIAN
So, if you don't mind me asking, what's your show about?

SAM
Well, it's basically *Drag Race*, but with gender transitioning instead of drag.

LUKE
Oooooh, I'd *love to see that*.

SAM
(shocked)
Really?

LUKE
Yeah! What a *train wreck* that would be.

A beat. Sam turns slowly to Jimmy. Absolute British death glare.

Jimmy doesn't want to meet her gaze.

INT. WEHO LGBT CENTER - DAY

Behind the reception desk of the WeHo center is KIERAN (60s-70s). He's reading a Chuck Tingle paperback -- the cover features a centaur in a business suit. He does not look embarrassed.

He stands up when he hears the doorbell to greet them, but doesn't look up at their faces yet. He's getting the sign-in book ready.

KIERAN
Hello. Welcome to the center, how can I help you? There's a sign-in sheet if you're looking to see a doctor or talk to a counselor.

JIMMY
Uh, well--

SAM
Um, it's, um--

Kieran finally looks up. Sees and recognizes Jimmy.

KIERAN
Oh! Right, right. Oh yeah, the form. Don't have to put your real name on the form. Don't worry, we're all friends here, no one's going to out you to the press or anything. And you're not the first celebrity to step in here.

JIMMY
Uh, no. I'm straight.

Kieran raises a skeptical eyebrow.

JIMMY (cont'd)
But out of curiosity... who--

Sam interrupts Jimmy, mercifully.

SAM
We're just... we had questions.

JIMMY
Er, not about *us*. Like...

Kieran steps out from behind the desk, and guides Jimmy and Sam over to a few chairs to talk more comfortably.

KIERAN
Please. Sit down. I'm Kieran, I'm running the front desk
(MORE)

KIERAN (cont'd)
today. There are no dumb questions here, and we're here to help you no matter where you are on your journey.

JIMMY
No-- I'm not-- there's no journey! Unless, Sam, are you on a--

SAM
Bog standard lesbian. I know where I'm at.

Kieran squints at Jimmy and Sam, trying to figure out what's going on.

SAM (cont'd)
Look, this is a really bad idea. Possibly a cluster of them. But Jimmy and I are doing research for a reality show pitch. It involves the trans community.

JIMMY
And since neither of us know *anything* about the trans community... we came by specifically to plead ignorance.

SAM
And stupidity.

JIMMY
That too.

KIERAN
Ah, I see. Well, you've come to the right place.

JIMMY
There's someone we can talk to?

KIERAN
Not right at the moment, but that's why we have the library. C'mon. This way.

INT. WEHO LGBT CENTER LIBRARY - DAY

It's a small library, filled with queer literature of all types.

Kieran leads them in.

KIERAN
We're open until eight tonight, unless you want to get a library card and check some of these out. And I can get you in touch with Sheri, she runs the trans and non-binary support group.

Sam starts perusing the books, stopping at the graphic novels.

JIMMY
That would be great!

SAM
Ooh! *Dykes to Watch Out For*. One of my favorites. It's the one where she came up with the Bechdel test.

Kieran starts plucking some novels off the shelf.

KIERAN
If you're interested in graphic novels about trans women, though, I'd recommend *Super Late Bloomer, My Life In Transition, First Year Out, Us*... Oh, this one's a good one. *Gender Queer*: *A Memoir*, if you're interested in an AFAB non-binary perspective.

JIMMY
Afab?

KIERAN
Assigned female at birth. As opposed to AMAB, assigned male at birth.

Jimmy picks up *Super Late Bloomer* and starts flipping through it.

SAM
Do you have any non-fiction prose books?

KIERAN
That we do. Classics are *Gender Euphoria*, and *Whipping Girl*.

Sam looks around the library at the depth of materials.

Jimmy hasn’t moved. He’s halfway through *Super Late Bloomer*, eyes wide. He turns a page, then another.

SAM
Yeah, if we're going to do this right, we're going to have to do a lot of swotting up. Do you have a library card application?

KIERAN
I can get that. And if you give me your phone numbers, I'll leave it with Sheri, and she'll get back to you.

SAM
That sounds great. Jimmy, doesn't that sound great?

Jimmy is entranced.

JIMMY
Huh, what? Oh.

Jimmy holds up *Super Late Bloomer*.

JIMMY (cont'd)
I always liked comic books. Growing up... I loved the X-Men.

KIERAN
Well, there's your first lesson then. They prefer to be called trans women.

JIMMY
No, no, that's not what--

KIERAN
Don't worry, Jimmy, I'm pulling your leg.

EXT. THE 405 - DUSK

The 405 is an infamous stretch of LA highway. It is bumper to bumper traffic.

Daria is driving home. Right blinker on, she's looking for an opening. It is not forthcoming.

DARIA
(to self)
Of all the words auto-correct keeps incorrectly suggesting to me, I think I like "gridlock" the least.

Daria's ringtone for her mother plays over the speakers: a kitschy classic-TV theme song.

Daria presses a button on her steering wheel to answer the call.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Hey Daria, how are you doing?

A gap appears in the right lane between two cares. As she steers towards the opening, the trailing car decides to take that moment to speed up and close the gap, nearly causing a collision.

DARIA
Motherf--!

The curse word is cut by honking horns.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
That bad? I'll call back later.

DARIA
No, no, Mom. I'm okay. I'm just driving home and stuck in traffic. Again. A Cybertruck crashed and it's playing havoc with the traffic.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Again? You told me a Cybertruck crashed yesterday too.

DARIA
Same Cybertruck. Still on fire.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Things going well with the job?

DARIA
Yeah, actually. Had a meeting for an interesting pitch. Team loves it. Going to bring the showrunners in for a second meeting.

Daria slams on the breaks when the car in front of her suddenly stops. She takes a deep, cleansing breath.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
What's it about?

DARIA
Can't give you details, but it's a show I think could do a lot of good. Change people's perceptions. Help people.

A pause.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
(pleadingly)
It's not one of those trans things, is it?

Daria sighs.

DARIA
Yes, Mom, it is. But it's good, I swear.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
I just worry you might be too much into the trans stuff.

DARIA
I worry about that too. Then I remember it affects every part of my life -- past, present, future -- and maybe being "too into it" is okay.

A small car merges into her lane from a small gap she leaves.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
I just... I worry. I don't want you to be alone, Daria. Maybe... maybe you don’t have to make this your whole identity.

DARIA
I don't. I have a career, a roof over my head. Food in my fridge. My board game group.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
But not a girlfriend.

DARIA
Mom.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Or a boyfriend.

DARIA
Mom! I'm a lesbian.
(beat)
On a technicality.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
I'm just saying, when am I going to have grandchildren?

DARIA
You're not. We've been over this. I don't have the equipment anymore.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
They could clone you.

DARIA
What?

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Like in Star Wars. You just need a hair sample, and *bam*, new you.

DARIA
Mom, Star Wars is science fiction.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
They said that about the Internet. I'm just saying, Daria, you don't know what the future holds. I've got a robot now!

DARIA
The roomba?

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
We call him "Orlando Broom."

Daria sighs.

DARIA
I'm focusing on my career now anyway. I can't get tied down to raising a clone. *Why are we talking about this?* Mom, why did you call me?

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
I just wanted to know if you're going to be flying home for Thanksgiving this year.

DARIA
We talked about this, Mom. I'm not safe in Florida.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Your dad brings his gun everywhere -- you'd be safe with him.

DARIA
(muttered)
Jesus Christ.
(back to Mom)
No, I mean it's not safe for trans people in Florida.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Oh it's not that bad. It must be terrifying in California.

DARIA
Mom, you *have* to stop watching The News Channel. They're lying to you.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Well, *all* the channels lie to you.

DARIA
No, Mom. That's another lie they tell you.

A deep, mournful sigh.

DARIA (cont'd)
Mom, can I ask you something?

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Anything, Schultzy.

DARIA
If there--

HOOOOOOOOOOONK! The driver behind her is simply impatient, and it just irritates Daria more.

DARIA (cont'd)
If there was a TV show that documented transitioning. That showed you exactly what I went through, and why I *had* to do it, and why people who aren't trans *can't* do it -- would you watch it?

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Well, if it was well done, I guess. Is that the TV show you got pitched?

DARIA
Sort of? Cause... I mean, you and Dad *do* try, but you also don't really...

Daria shakes her head.

DARIA (cont'd)
There are *so many* misconceptions. Things you *thought* you knew, or things you were told that just weren't true.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Maybe. I'm sorry sweetie. We're just... from a different time. We didn't have transgender people back then. Or-- maybe we did, but we didn't talk about them. We certainly didn't see them on TV. Except maybe Donahue.

A gap finally opens up. Finally, an exit from this carpocolyptic hellscape.

DARIA
Ooh. Mom, I've got to call you back.

DARIA'S MOM (O.S.)
Okay. Drive safe. Let us know about Thanksgiving. Love you.

DARIA
Love you too, Mom. And tell dad I love him too.

Daria finally, *finally* gets off the 405.

ACT III

INT. DARIA'S APARTMENT BEDROOM - NIGHT (MOS)

(Music plays.)

On the nightstand, a paperback book, in a bookstore bag with a receipt sticking out. "WE'RE GONNA NEED A BIGGER HOST: THE AUTOBIOGRAPHY OF JIMMY HOWARD."

Daria lies on her stomach, flipping through a stack of printed briefs and scribbled script pages. Half are covered in notes. Half are stained with fast food.

She highlights a line. Circles another. Flips a page. Smirks.

INT. SAM'S GUEST HOUSE BEDROOM - NIGHT (MOS)

Sam sits cross-legged on her bed, hair tied up, deep in *Whipping Girl*. The book is already full of post-it notes.

She reads. Stops. Rereads. Frowns.

Nods slowly.

INT. JIMMY'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (MOS)

Jimmy sits propped against the headboard, alone with *Super Late Bloomer*.

He turns a page. Lingers. His face doesn't move.

EXT. LOS ANGELES - DAWN

The city rolls slowly into morning.

(The music fades out as the sun crests the hills.)

We hear a short phone call.

SHERI (V.O.)
Hello, is this Samantha Culver?

SAM (V.O.)
Speaking.

SHERI (V.O.)
This is Sheri Winston. I'm the counselor at the WeHo center. Kieran said you wanted to talk. How's coffee later today?

INT. COFFEESHOP - DAY

SHERI (45) is a trans woman. Red floral top. Flowing grey skirt. *Prominent Adam's apple*.

As Jimmy and Sam come in, they immediately head over to her table for handshakes.

Sheri's prepared with a little yellow notepad. Sam brought her laptop.

SHERI
You must be Sam... and you... brought a game show host?

JIMMY
(alarmed)
A game show host? Where? I'm not going to let them drag me back to Camp Martindale! I just escaped!

Sam rolls her eyes.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Hi. Jimmy Howard. Yes, *that* one.

Sheri and Jimmy shake hands.

SHERI
Is he always like this?

JIMMY
Yes.

SAM
No.

They take seats.

SHERI
So, Sam, Jimmy, how can I help you?

JIMMY
We want to do a reality TV show about gender transitioning.

SHERI
What, like a documentary for the Discovery Channel or something?

Jimmy and Sam shift uncomfortably in their seats.

JIMMY
Uh, not exactly. Sam. Why don't you explain it?

SAM
(an edge)
But *you* explain it so *well*.

JIMMY
It was *your idea*, Sam.

Sam accepts defeat for now.

SAM
What would happen if you took, say, seven or eight cisgender men, and, uh, told them that if they successfully transitioned to women, they'd win a million dollars?

A pause. A *long, shocked* pause.

SHERI
That's *INSANE*.

SAM
Yep. Exactly what we thought too.

JIMMY
But... *aside* from the fact that it's completely insane?

SAM
Daft.

JIMMY
Meshugge.

SAM
Mental.

JIMMY
Other than *that*... what *would* happen?

Sheri looks between the two of them, eyes wide.

SHERI
Oh my god. You're *serious*.

SAM
I... It's... complicated. But... there's interest. From a streaming service.

SHERI
No. Absolutely *not*. Being trans... it's not a... costume, or a choice. When people are forced to live as a gender that isn't theirs, it can cause severe dysphoria, depression, anxiety...

Sheri grits her teeth.

SHERI (cont'd)
Look, I'm glad you came to talk, but this is... deeply ignorant.

SAM
Yeah. We know.

JIMMY
We know these are dumb questions. But that's where we're starting from.

SHERI
What you're proposing could hurt people. *Badly*. Permanently.

Sam stares into the middle distance.

SAM
Oh, god. It's starting to become real.

Sheri and Jimmy both look at her.

JIMMY
Sam?

SAM
Yeah, I knew this was going to be a train wreck but... I didn't think it could *hurt* anyone...

She exhales sharply.

Sheri claps her hands, places them in front of her face, and takes a deep breath through her nose.

SHERI
Right then. Tell me the whole story. Let's start at the top.

INT. DARIA'S OFFICE - DAY

Chandra knocks on Daria's door.

CHANDRA
Hey, Daria. Got a minute?

DARIA
Sure thing. What's up, Chandra?

CHANDRA
Just wanted to let you know we put out a casting call for *Gender Island*.

Disbelief. A beat.

DARIA
You what?

CHANDRA
Well, not just for *Gender Island*. If we don't greenlight it, we'll redirect the talent to some other reality show, like "The Real American Mounties," or "Red Bull Presents: Extreme Haferflocken" Just keeping the pipeline moving.

DARIA
You put out a casting call for a show that hasn't even been *approved* yet?

CHANDRA
It's the tech industry, Daria. You know the drill. Build the plane mid-flight.

DARIA
Did you even *talk* to the showrunners?

CHANDRA
We were going to, yesterday. But Sam got sick.

DARIA
When did the call go out?

CHANDRA
Yesterday afternoon. Why?

A slow, sick beat.

Daria looks down at her phone. Quiet horror blooming.

INT. COFFEESHOP - DAY

Sam's phone rings. It's Daria.

SAM
Sorry, Sheri. I have to take this.

Sheri nods, and continues talking to Jimmy, while Sam heads outside.

EXT. OUTSIDE COFFEESHOP - DAY - CONTINUOUS

SAM
Hey Daria. Everything alright? Did Garden decide to pass after all?

DARIA (V.O.)
Not exactly. I think they're going to move quite fast on *Gender Island* when you make your pitch. Maybe too fast.

SAM
Daria... how fast is *too fast?*

DARIA (V.O.)
They already put out a casting call.

SAM
WHAT!? THE--

A passing truck drowns out the profanity with a long honk.

DARIA (V.O.)
I *know*.

SAM
Daria, I don’t even have a *show* yet! Right now I’m in West Hollywood making an ass of myself in front of a trans counselor just trying to figure out if I’m going to hell for *thinking* about this!

DARIA (V.O.)
Really?

SAM
Yes, *really!* I'm not ready to be cancelled, Daria! I haven't even been *subscribed!*

INT. COFFEESHOP - DAY

Jimmy and Sheri continue their conversation.

SHERI
So, let's say you actually do this. First of all, I'm ninety-nine point nine percent sure this is illegal in the U.S. Hell, it's probably illegal *everywhere*.

JIMMY
Should I be taking notes?

SHERI
Yes, yes you should.

Sheri pulls out a little yellow pad like her own, and a plastic pen.

SHERI (cont'd)
Just keep it. I start a new pad when I see a new patient, so I don't mix up people's notes.

JIMMY
Thanks.

Jimmy starts speaking while writing.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Probably... illegal... everywhere.

SHERI
Underline that. Twice.

Two lines dart across the paper.

JIMMY
Okay, but let's say we *do* find a jurisdiction where it *wasn't* illegal. How would we need to set something like this up?

Sheri sighed.

SHERI
Well, the most important thing is *informed consent*. You're going to need to tell them exactly what's going to happen. Every step of the way. You are intending to permanently change human bodies for ratings.

JIMMY
There's precedent. There was a spate of 'surgery TV' shows in the 2000s.

Sheri glares.

SHERI
Jimmy. Answer me. Are all game show hosts criminally insane?

JIMMY
I can't speak for myself, but... maybe. I mean, Eubanks... Woolery...

Jimmy shakes his head.

JIMMY (cont'd)
Nah. Alex Trebek was a *saint*. Though he *was* Canadian. That might be the difference.

SHERI
God help me. Jimmy, look at me.

Jimmy looks into Sheri's eyes. No mask.

SHERI (cont'd)
You are about to change people's bodies. For *money*. For *television*. You don't get to be flippant about that.

Jimmy doesn't argue.

Sheri's voice continues over --

BEGIN INTERCUT -- SHERI'S MONOLOGUE / CONTESTANT APPLICATIONS (MOS)

INT. VICTOR'S LONELY STUDIO APARTMENT - DAY

VICTOR (androgynous, ham actor, theatre kid) lives a lonely, spartan lifestyle, except for a bunch of costumes and a full vanity and makeup kit.

Victor prints out and fills out the form for "UNTITLED GARDEN ALPHA PROJECT" It's part of a stack of forms he hasn't yet filled out.

SHERI (V.O.)
This isn't a *makeover*. It's not a *prank*. It's not a *weekend experiment*.

INT. JETT'S VENICE BEACH APARTMENT - DAY

The decor is *GAY*.

BRADLEY (20s, shy, lumberjack-looking, well bearded) is filling out the form on a desk. His boyfriend, JETT (20s, effeminate femboy), comes up behind him, goosing him.

Jett is curious about the form. Bradley shows him. Jett scans it -- then takes a second, more serious look.

SHERI (O.S.)
Even if you can get a doctor -- some really unethical son of a bitch to *somehow* prescribe hormones. Or god forbid -- *perform surgery!* You need to tell *everyone* involved *exactly* what it will do.

INT. JACOB'S APARTMENT - DAY

GOOCH (20s, chaos gremlin, personal disaster, stoner) comes in, wild-eyed and excited, with two copies of the form, to JACOB (20s, personal trainer, jock), who is playing Madden on his couch. It's the apartment of a bachelor who works out. Creatine powder on the kitchen counter. They read it over and high-five.

SHERI (O.S.)
Sexual changes. Breast growth. Fat redistribution. Fertility. Muscle loss. Emotional changes. What might reverse if they stop, and what might not.

INT. RAFAEL'S ROOM.

RAFAEL (20s, trans man, Latino) sits on his bed, eyeing the application form with skepticism. He crumples it up, tosses it in the wastepaper bin.

RAFAEL'S MOM (50s) comes in, carrying a couple of dresses for Rafael to try on. Rafael is aghast and frustrated, shaking his head in disbelief. His mother just lays them down on his bed. Rafael thinks and gets the application form out of the garbage and uncrumples it.

SHERI (O.S.)
If they stay on these hormones for long enough, these changes become *permanent*.

INT. OSCAR'S BACKYARD - DAY

OSCAR (20s, smarmy conservative, polo shirt) is barbecuing with his Red-Hatted friends, REG (20s, white) and HENRY (20s, white). He gets a fax with the application form on it, and looks over at it, raising an eyebrow.

SHERI (O.S.)
Nobody. And I mean *nobody*, goes through *transition* just for the hell of it.

INT. MACDONALD RESIDENCE - DAY

KAYLA MACDONALD (19-20, tomboy) is visibly angry at her brother, ETHAN MACDONALD (20s, autistic-coded, nervous) for some reason. After a fight, *she* goes to the computer, prints out the form -- and *forges her brother's name* on it.

SHERI (O.S.)
God help me, I put off my own transition for *decades*, just because I wasn't *completely* sure. Even then I treated it like an experiment at first.

INT. LEONARD & LEONARD'S MOM'S APARTMENT - DAY

LEONARD (early 20s, computer science student) is showing MARIANNE (40's), his mom, the form. She's dressed for work -- courtroom, actually, judging by the number of law books in the place. She looks over it, and shrugs, giving

a thumbs up. Leonard pushes aside a few computer science books to start filling out the form.

SHERI (O.S.)
(a beat)
I *want* the changes that are happening to my body. *Need* them, in fact, in order to feel *human*, instead of... a meat robot.

END INTERCUT

INT. COFFEESHOP - DAY

SHERI
(a beat))
If you try to make cis men, and ask them to go through all that for the chance at some money?
(a beat)
To basically go through what *I* went through *before* I started on hormones? *Nobody's going to do that*.
(long beat)
Nobody.

A long silence, Jimmy looking at Sheri. Sheri looking back. Jimmy has been affected by the monologue. He doesn't know why yet, but he has.

Jimmy opens his mouth--then closes it again.

Sam runs back into the coffeeshop.

JIMMY
Hey, Sam.

SAM
Jimmy, we're in trouble. I've got Daria here on the line. I'll put her on speaker.

JIMMY
Hey Daria. What's up?

DARIA
It's not good news.

SAM
They put out a *casting call*. For *Gender Island*.

SHERI
Ha. Good luck with *that*.

Sheri takes a sip of coffee.

SAM
And they got three hundred and eighty-five applicants within the first eighteen hours.

Sheri spit-takes.

CUT TO BLACK:

END OF PILOT